a) Steps in Processing Coffee

i). Roasting

It is the important step in the processing of coffee. Roasting is the most important process for the development of characteristic flavour and aroma of the coffee bean. Apart from these benefits, roasting also helps to reduce the moisture content and the amount of a tannin called chlorogenic acid (a non-volatile acid) and the fat content develops, a group of essential oils known as caffeol. The colour of the bean changes from green to brown due to caramelization of the sugar content of the bean. Roasting time depends upon the required variety of coffee.

ii). Grinding

The bulk of roasted beans is ground to powder and sold as ground coffee. Roasted beans are ground to three sizes, namely, fine, medium, and coarse powder. Coarse ground powder retains aroma and flavour better and longer than fine ground powder. Coarse ground powder is more suitable for preparing coffee decoction by percolation. On the other hand, fine ground coffee gives a decoction with good aroma. Combination of these two grades in the ratio of 90% of fine powder and10% of coarse powder gives an excellent quality coffee.

iii). Blending

Two types of coffee powder are marketed, in the name of pure coffee, prepared from coffee beans only and other containing chicory. Strength, flavour, aroma and acidity are the major criteria considered to judge the quality of coffee.

iv). Packaging

The aroma and flavour in the ground coffee is highly unstable and it should be properly packed under vacuum or can also be fresh roasted and ground before brewing and is practiced even today by several taste experts in households.

v). Staleness

The green coffee bean once is ground and exposed to air the bean has limited storage life. This staling of coffee is accompanied by loss of carbon-di-oxide and oxidation of guaicol and changes in unsaturated volatile compounds. The freshness of the ground coffee is maintained commercially by sealing in a container under vacuum. Storing in a cool place will delay staling. Once a can of coffee is opened, contact with atmosphere with moisture should be kept to a minimum.

b) Adulterants in Coffee

- If chicory is added and not mentioned on the label, it is considered as adulterant.
- Cherry husk is sometimes used as an adulterant.
- Burnt sugar, tamarind seed, used coffee powder and saw dust are also used as adulterants.



Caffeine

It is an alkaloid substance producing the stimulating property. Especially it stimulates the central nervous system. The longer the brewing time of coffee the more is caffeine extracted. It can be removed chemically from the bean to produce decaffeinated coffee.

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